

MRIDANGINI

UI/UX Design Choices Documentation

1. Project Overview

Introduction

Mridangini is an e-commerce platform built not just to sell, but to celebrate — carrying forward the living musical traditions of Assam and the Northeast into the digital age. Built as a fully functional web application with dedicated pages for product cataloguing, user authentication, order management, and customer support, the platform delivers a complete end-to-end shopping experience. It features a category-based shop with individual product listings, an account creation and login system, a cart and checkout flow, and a contact form for direct customer engagement.

Website Name: Mridangini

Tagline: Sound of Your Soil and Soul

Type: E-commerce (Cultural / Artisanal)

Target Audience: Music enthusiasts, cultural preservationists, instrument collectors, and general buyers interested in North-Eastern heritage

Core Pages: Home, Shop (Catalogue), About, Orders, Contact, Create Account / Login

2. Design Philosophy

Mridangini's visual and interaction design is rooted in cultural authenticity balanced with clean, accessible e-commerce conventions. Every design decision reinforces the brand's identity as a bridge between traditional artisanship and the modern digital marketplace.

2.1 Cultural Identity

The design draws direct visual inspiration from the gamusa — a traditional Assamese handwoven cloth — whose motifs are used as a decorative border running across the top of every page. This provides an immediate, consistent cultural signal to the user.

- Gamusa-inspired red and white repeating pattern runs as a full-width top border.
- Artistic logo featuring a lady playing an instrument in charcoal blue reinforces the artisanal identity.
- High-quality, artistic photography of instruments maintains an editorial, heritage feel over a typical product-catalogue aesthetic.

2.2 Minimalism in Service of Culture

The layout avoids visual clutter so that the instruments and their cultural stories remain the focal point. Warm neutral backgrounds (Pearl, ButterCream) act as a canvas that lets product photography breathe.

2.3 Accessibility & Inclusivity

The platform is usable by the broadest possible audience, including users with visual impairments and users on low-end devices.

3. Colour Palette

The colour palette is warm, earthy, and culturally resonant. It reflects the textures of handwoven cloth, raw wood, and aged brass — materials central to traditional instrument-making in the Northeast.

Color Name	Hex Code	Role/Usage	Rationale
Pearl	#EAE0C8	Background (70%)	Warm neutral that evokes aged paper and natural materials; easy on the eyes for long browsing sessions.
Butter-Cream	#EFE1CE	Surfaces – Cards, Forms	Slightly warmer than Pearl; differentiates interactive surfaces from base backgrounds.

Charcoal Blue	#202833	Secondary (20%) – Text, Nav, Logo	Deep, authoritative tone used for primary text, buttons, navigation, and the logo illustration.
Maroon	#800000	Accent (10%) – CTAs, Links, Headings	Bold cultural accent drawn from gamusa red, used sparingly for call-to-action buttons and key headings to guide user attention.

4. Typography

Two complementary typefaces form the typographic system, creating a balance between artistic character and readable clarity.

4.1 Xanh Mono

A monospaced serif typeface used for display text, headings, hero copy, page titles, and the brand name logo text.

- Classification: Monospaced serif
- Usage: Hero headings ('Rooted in Tradition, Made to Resonate.'), page-level titles ('Get in Touch', 'Create Account'), brand wordmark ('mridangini')
- Rationale: The monospaced quality lends a handcrafted, artisanal rhythm, each character occupying equal space mirrors the repetitive, deliberate craft of weaving and instrument-making. The serif character adds cultural weight and heritage.

4.2 DM Sans

A clean, geometric sans-serif used for body copy, navigation labels, form fields, product descriptions, and UI labels.

- Classification: Geometric sans-serif

- Usage: Navigation menu, body paragraphs, product prices, form placeholders, footer text, button labels
- Rationale: DM Sans provides excellent legibility at small sizes and on screens, balancing Xanh Mono's artistic character with functional clarity. Its geometric neutrality ensures navigation and product information are easy to scan.

5. Layout & Navigation

5.1 Global Header

A persistent sticky navigation bar appears at the top of every page.

- Logo (left): Circular artistic icon + 'mridangini' wordmark + tagline 'sound of your soil and soul'
- Navigation links (centre): Home | Shop | About | Orders | Contact , clearly labelled in DM Sans
- Utility icons (right): Search, User Account, Shopping Cart — universally recognised icons following real-world conventions.
- Gamusa border: A full-width decorative red-and-white woven pattern immediately below the header on every page, reinforcing cultural identity consistently.

5.2 Page Layout

Pages use a single-column or two-column layout depending on context, with generous whitespace that supports the artistic photography style.

- Home: Full-width hero section with headline, subtext, and 'Explore Collection' CTA; instruments displayed as artistic cut-outs.
- Shop / Catalogue: Multi-column product grid with product photo, name, price, 'Shop Now' and 'Add to Cart' buttons.
- Contact: Two-column — contact details (left) and contact form (right).
- About –Page: Uses a two-column layout — a large, detailed circular illustration in Charcoal Blue ink style sits on the left within a Butter-Cream card, while the brand story text occupies the right column. The heading "About Mridangini" is set in Xanh Mono in Maroon, followed by three body paragraphs in DM Sans. The Pearl background and warm card panel keep the page visually consistent with the rest of the site.

- Create Account / Login: Left-aligned title with right-aligned form — consistent split layout across auth pages.

5.3 Footer

Three-column footer with Brand identity (left), Quick Links (centre), and Newsletter sign-up (right). Social media icons in brand colours provide further navigation pathways.

6. Components & Interaction Design

6.1 Buttons

Buttons are a critical touchpoint for user action and are designed for clarity and confidence.

- **Solid Maroon (#800000) fill, white DM Sans label, rounded corners — used for 'Add to Cart', 'Create Account', 'Send Message', 'Explore Collection', 'Add to cart': Primary CTA**
- **Dark (Charcoal Blue) fill, white label — used for 'Shop Now' on product cards, distinguishing browse intent from purchase intent: Secondary CTA**

6.2 Forms

Forms are used for Contact, Account Creation, and Login. Design principles applied:

- Clear field labels and placeholder text.
- Fields are visually separated on a ButterCream (#EFE1CE) surface distinguishing the interactive zone from background
- Error handling: Fields should use inline validation with plain-language error messages — no error codes.
- 'Already have an account? Login' link below the Create Account form supports user control and prevents dead ends.

6.3 Product Cards

Each product card in the shop catalogue displays:

- Artistic close-up photography of the instrument (warm, editorial tone)
- Instrument name in DM Sans bold
- Price in Indian Rupees (₹) — formatted clearly in Charcoal Blue

- Two action buttons: 'Shop Now' (browse / detail) and 'Add to Cart' (direct purchase)

This two-button approach supports both browsing and impulsive purchase behaviour, catering to different user types.

6.5 Logo & Branding

The circular logo features an artistic illustration of a woman playing a traditional instrument, rendered in Charcoal Blue. This reinforces the brand narrative — Mridangini which is named after the mridanga - a traditional khol like instrument, featured in a lot of Assamese poetry, like: "Bajak Doba, Bajak xangkha, Bajak mridang khol". It is also related to a lot of legends in traditional mythologies, remarkably with Ganesh.

7. References

- Nielsen, J. (1994). 10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design. Nielsen Norman Group. <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/>
- Kirkpatrick, A., O Connor, J., Campbell, A., & Cooper, M. (Eds.). (2025). Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1. W3C Recommendation. <https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/>